

CALCULATING YOUR CUT: CALORIES FOR LOSING FAT WITHOUT LOSING MUSCLE

The BMR-to-deficit math for cutting, built for a body that already has muscle to protect.

If you've already built real muscle and you're trying to lean out for a specific date, a photo shoot, a weigh-in, a beach trip, without losing what you worked for, the calorie math has to be tighter than a generic "eat less" plan. The mechanism is the same as any weight loss: eat less than you burn. What changes for cutting is how precisely that number needs to be sized, and how much more protein has to carry the load.

Your Starting Point: BMR

Basal metabolic rate (BMR) is the energy your body burns at rest, just running your organs, brain, and basic functions. The Mifflin-St Jeor equation estimates it from weight, height, and age:

- **Men:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) + 5$
- **Women:** $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) - 161$

Take a 29-year-old man cutting for an event, 88 kg (about 194 lbs), 178 cm tall (about 5'10"), a few years of consistent training behind him. His BMR: $(10 \times 88) + (6.25 \times 178) - (5 \times 29) + 5 = 880 + 1,112.5 - 145 + 5 = \mathbf{1,853 \text{ calories}}$.

BMR to TDEE: Accounting for a Real Training Load

Multiply BMR by an activity factor to get total daily energy expenditure (TDEE): sedentary is $\times 1.2$, lightly active $\times 1.375$, moderately active $\times 1.55$, very active $\times 1.725$. A lifter running four hard training days a week plus conditioning finishers, like Echelon's Cutting base program, lands at very active. $1,853 \times 1.725 = \mathbf{3,196 \text{ calories}}$, that is his maintenance number before any deficit is applied.

Sizing the Deficit: Tighter, Not Just Smaller

General weight loss can work with a fairly forgiving deficit. Cutting from an already-lean, already-muscular starting point has less margin for error, there is more trained tissue at risk and less spare body fat cushioning mistakes. A deficit of roughly **15-20% below TDEE** is still the right range, aggressive enough to see visible change on a timeline, conservative enough to protect the muscle. For our example, that is 3,196 minus 15-20%, or roughly **2,550 to 2,720 calories a day**. The percentage is similar to general weight loss, what is different is how precisely it needs to be tracked and how much protein is prioritized within it.

Protein Is the Non-Negotiable

In a cut, protein is not just "a macro", it is the thing standing between "lighter" and "leaner." Aim high, meaningfully higher than a general weight-loss target, a portion roughly the size of your palm and then some at every meal, four to five times a day. Carbohydrates should be sized around your hardest training days, more on heavy lifting and conditioning days, less on rest days, since they are what keeps your lifts from collapsing mid-deficit. Fat fills in the remainder, kept moderate, not stripped to zero.

Supplement Support for a Cut

A cut makes hitting an already-high protein target through food alone genuinely difficult day after day. A whey protein option like **XS™ Whey Protein** is a straightforward way to close that gap without adding much food volume on top of a reduced calorie budget. **XS™ Creatine+** is worth a look too, as a general strength-support option for anyone still training hard to hold onto lifting performance while calories are down. Both are available through [the Echelon Goods shop](#) for anyone who wants to look into them further.

What This Means for You

- Cutting runs on the same BMR-to-TDEE math as any weight loss, calculated from your own weight, height, age, and activity level.
- A 15-20% deficit below TDEE is the general range, sized tightly and tracked more precisely than a casual weight-loss approach.
- Protein is the priority macro here, above general weight-loss targets, it's what protects the muscle you are trying to reveal, not just lose weight around.
- Recalculate as your weight drops, a lighter, leaner body has a lower maintenance number than the one you started with.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or nutrition advice. If you have a medical condition, a history of disordered eating, or are taking medication, talk to your doctor before beginning an aggressive cutting phase.